

C03 EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS | P

Intent : Enable organizations, families and individuals to prepare and respond to diverse emergency situations.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects to undertake a risk assessment, create an emergency management plan for natural, human-caused, technological and health-related emergencies and educate occupants on the plan to support emergency preparedness and response.

Issue : Natural disasters kill around 90,000 people and affect close to 160 million people worldwide every year, with both an immediate and long-term impact on human lives and built spaces.¹ Older adults, individuals with disabilities, pregnant women and children may have special needs during an emergency and are particularly vulnerable when disaster strikes.¹ The U.S. Federal Emergency Management Agency estimates about 40–60% of small businesses permanently close following a disaster due to the lack of a comprehensive disaster preparedness plan with proper mitigation strategies.² Beyond natural disasters, infectious disease epidemics have increased in the 21st century, involving rapid global spread due to travel, trade and urbanization.^{3,4} The COVID-19 pandemic infected six million people and spread to almost every continent within five months, impacting the social and economic livelihood of the global population on an incalculable scale.⁵

Solutions : An effective emergency management plan requires an understanding of potential local hazards, the needs of vulnerable groups, the responsibilities of the emergency response team and building response capabilities.⁶ Emergency management plans, including risk assessments, occupant drills and enhanced emergency communications, can help organizations be better prepared to handle unforeseen events, minimize occupant confusion and improve coordination and safety during emergency situations.^{3,7–11} Robust emergency preparedness and response measures can also help to slow the spread of infectious disease and minimize secondary mortality.¹²

PART 1 DEVELOP EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS PLAN

For All Spaces:

The following requirements are met:

- a. A risk assessment is undertaken to address at minimum the following:
 1. Identify project assets (e.g., employees, facilities).
 2. Establish a process for occupants or groups who may be more vulnerable (e.g., older adults, people with disabilities, pregnant women, children) to confidentially identify specific needs they may have during an emergency.¹³
 3. Evaluate potential impacts of relevant hazards and identify high-risk hazards.
 4. Determine emergency management planning priorities.
- b. An emergency management plan is in place outlining response in the case of emergency situations within the building or surrounding community, addressing at minimum the following hazards:
 1. Natural (e.g., flood, tsunami, wildfire, earthquake, heatwave).
 2. Fire.
 3. Health (e.g., acute medical emergency, infectious disease pandemic).
 4. Technological (e.g., power loss, chemical spill, explosion).
 5. Human-caused (e.g., civil unrest, active shooter, terrorism).
- c. The emergency management plan meets the following requirements:
 1. Incorporates annual (at minimum) inventory and maintenance of building emergency response resources (e.g., first aid kits, automated external defibrillators (AEDs), emergency notification system, personal protective equipment) and operations capabilities (e.g., backup power, remote management systems).
 2. Includes a list of specialized personnel that is updated annually (at minimum) and includes roles and contact information of the emergency response team.¹³
 3. Plan is reviewed and updated (as needed) on an annual basis and is easily accessible to all regular occupants.
- d. Regular occupants are provided education and training on emergency preparedness and response, including the following:
 1. Communications about the emergency management plan and related resources, including guidance by relevant local-, state-, regional- or global-level emergency response agencies (e.g., WHO, government emergency management agency or equivalent), annually (at minimum), to employees during new employee onboarding and during an emergency event.
 2. Practice drills or other operations-based or discussion-based exercises conducted annually (at minimum) for each high-risk hazard identified in the risk assessment, and conducted every two years (at minimum) for other hazards covered under the emergency management plan.¹³

REFERENCES

1. WHO. Environmental health in emergencies : Vulnerable groups. Public Health Management of Chemical Incidents.
2. Mike S. Make Your Business Resilient.
3. World Health Organization. Managing Epidemics.; 2018. <https://www.who.int/emergencies/diseases/managing-epidemics-interactive.pdf>. Accessed June 3, 2020.

4. World Health Organization. WHO's Work in Emergencies: Prepare, Prevent, Detect and Respond - Annual Report 2018. World Health Organization; 2018. <https://www.who.int/emergencies/who-work-in-emergencies/en/>. Accessed June 3, 2020.
5. World Health Organization. Coronavirus Disease (COVID-19) Situation Report - 134.; 2020. https://www.who.int/docs/default-source/coronaviruse/situation-reports/20200602-covid-19-sitrep-134.pdf?sfvrsn=cc95e5d5_2. Accessed June 3, 2020.
6. Occupational Health and Safety Administration. How to Plan for Workplace Emergencies and Evacuations. 2001.
7. Lockwood NR. Crisis Management in Today's Business Environment: HR's Strategic Role.; 2005. <https://www.shrm.org/hr-today/news/hr-magazine/Documents/1205RQuartpdf.pdf>. Accessed October 21, 2019.
8. Skryabina E, Reedy G, Amlôt R, Jaye P, Riley P. What is the value of health emergency preparedness exercises? A scoping review study. *Int J Disaster Risk Reduct.* 2017;21:274-283. doi:10.1016/j.ijdrr.2016.12.010
9. Occupational Safety and Health Administration. Evacuation Plans and Procedures eTool | Emergency Action Plan - Develop & Implement an Emergency Action Plan (EAP). <https://www.osha.gov/SLTC/etools/evacuation/implementation.html>. Accessed June 3, 2020.
10. American Red Cross Ready Rating. SMB Prepared Playbook. 2015. <https://www.readyrating.org/Resource-Center/All-Resources/smb-prepared-playbook>. Accessed June 4, 2020.
11. U.S. Small Business Administration. Disaster Preparedness and Recovery Plan.; 2019. [https://www.sba.gov/sites/default/files/2019-08/2019 DPRP 3-2b-FINAL.pdf](https://www.sba.gov/sites/default/files/2019-08/2019%20DPRP%203-2b-FINAL.pdf). Accessed June 4, 2020.
12. World Health Organization. COVID-19 Strategy Update - 14 April 2020.; 2020. <https://www.who.int/publications-detail/covid-19-strategy-update---14-april-2020>. Accessed June 3, 2020.
13. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). (2015). Planning for an emergency: Strategies for identifying and engaging at-risk groups. A guidance document for emergency managers. <https://www.cdc.gov/nceh/hsb/disaster/atriskguidance.pdf>.